HOW TO PREVENT A HEART ATTACK



KNOW YOUR GENETICS
South Asians are more prone to heart disease than their western counterparts. Cut down other risk factors such as smoking, even passive smoking, and wear masks in polluted air

KEEP CHOLESTROL, BLOOD PRESSURE AND SUGAR UNDER CONTROL
They are the silent killers for the heart in the long run





OPT FOR MODERATE PHYSICAL ACTIVITY
Too little or too much activity are detrimental for your heart health. Opt for something moderate such as walking, yoga or swimming

CONTROL CHRONIC STRESS
Take time out to look after yourself. If the stress is constant, look for solutions and seek help if needed





DON'T UNDER OR OVER TEST
Should you have many risk factors for heart disease, two tests a year are enough or as recommended by a doctor. Otherwise, an annual check-up should suffice. It is best to start with primary testing and then consult a doctor for invasive tests, if required



"If you have had health problems for 20-30 years, then the damage is already done by the time you reach your 40s and 50s"

DR SHASHIDHAR
Head, Interventional Cardiology, Fortis, Bannerghatta Road, Bengaluru

unblock clogged arteries. One of the most common and advanced procedures of modern medicine today, the surgery is not only minimally invasive but also takes just an hour to perform. Keyhole or laparoscopic surgeries are fairly common; in many hospitals, computers assist surgeons for better precision. Cardiac stents, the tiny, expandable mesh coils used to treat narrow or blocked arteries, have progressed immensely in the past three decades. "Not only are they safer to deploy but are also far more effective," says Dr Seth. "In the 1990s, we had bare metal stents, which had around 25 per cent chances of problems such as the inner lining of arteries multiplying and forming scar tissue which would create blockages again. Then, we had the next generation of medicated stents with which there are less than 5 per cent chances of subsequent problems. Today, we have thinner stents, plus intravascular imaging technology that lets us fully assess the results of each surgery, with chances of future problems being only 1 or 2 per cent." The new generation of stents are bio-dissolvable, which means they dissolve over two to three years and leave the artery open without any permanent implant.

Today, most hospitals use Bioresorbable Vascular Scaffolds made of naturally occurring elements in the body, and therefore dissolvable over time. New stents also include bio-engineered ones (made of cobalt and chromium mesh, and thinner in size), drug-eluting stents (coated with medicinal substances that prevent blood clots from reoccurring) and dual therapy stents (that come with advanced cell technology, which boosts growth of healthy tissue and speedier recovery).

However, despite the advances, experts say, many patients still believe heart disease means open heart surgery. The fact is, doctors use surgery only in serious cases and as the last resort, preferring advanced drugs to do the job instead. These include enhanced external counter pulsation, which compresses the blood vessels in the lower limbs to increase blood flow to the heart. The treatment may lead to blood vessels opening into small channels that become extra branches, or a natural bypass. Another treatment being used is vasodilation or the process of opening or dilating blood vessels with the help of medicines to allow blood to flow more easily through the heart. A variety of next-gen blood thinners, such as edoxaban, apixaban, dabigatran and rivaroxaban, also help prevent blood clots and changes in the heart, but with less side-effects than similar medications in the past.

Post-diagnosis, the one big change, doctors cannot stop emphasising, must be in one's lifestyle. Simply choosing the right thing to eat and doing moderate exercise—even if it means just walking from the train station to your office—are enough. Experts say the key to a good heart is a balanced diet of fresh unprocessed food, roughly 10,000 steps a day, and regular doctor visits. "My patients often complain that they don't have time to go to the gym and that they work all day. I always ask them one thing: is it worth your life?" says Dr Limaye of Fortis. The heart imposes just one caveat: pay it a little more attention. Given the genetics, poor dietary choices, low exercise regimes and heightened stress, the risk of heart disease, and at an early age, is a given. One needs to use the wealth of diagnostic tools to catch it in time. Starting early makes all the difference—in saving your heart, and yourself. ■